

Weekly Reading Reflections #2: Sergio Monterroso

Politics of Documentation & Thinking Archivally

Politics of Documentation

Considering our past discussions, one constant that has appeared in our readings is how control of heritage discourse is crucial to a state. Rosie Bsheer asserts that the state's controlled historical narratives are used to "pacify opponents, diversify national economies, and monumentalize state power." They have an incentive to police knowledge production to crush domestic opposition during times of crisis. Bsheer used Saudi Arabia as her main example of a government taking intense actions to guard or further their authorized historical narratives.

Saudi Arabia's AHD "necessarily relied on the simultaneous mass destruction of historical as well as sacred space across the country, space that countered official Saudi history." Her lecture helped me understand that when a regime is threatened, one of the weapons in their large arsenal of state-rebuilding is responding with historical revisionism, and weaponizing the archives to territorialize history and pacify opposition. The United States was a core conspirator in these efforts in Saudi Arabia, as well as international media outlets who legitimized these authorized heritage discourses. In short, they won their fight to weaponize history by destroying archives and pushing their version of history out as the "truth" while historians are left scrambling for the whole "truth."

Taking these facts and applying them to our class, it's sufficient to say that the politics of archives and the documents that they hold is very intense. Although we don't see acts of war in the United States, we do see in-fighting on archival handlings and how we are to interpret these handlings. In class, we discussed the example of how it's dangerous to "construct" history where there really isn't anything, which can happen easily in a fight about the archives. We also discussed how easily history is accepted when it is regulated: the more regulated it is, the less accurate but more accepted it is... the less regulated it is, the more accurate but less accepted it is.

Thinking Archivally

The construction of an archive must be traced first to a question that, although seemingly simple on its face, is actually pretty difficult: what is an archive? The High Theory podcast covered various answers to the question: taking archive as a metaphor with a story of the past (Foucault), archives as a Freudian response to death drive and memory (Derrida), also considering the body as an archive based on what memory "deposits" in us (Singh), and the traditional answer by the Society of American Archivists that archives are just documents and records that historians interpret. The answer I best relate to is the final one, which allows the historian to be the storywriter and the archive to be the evidence to that story. It's a boring interpretation, but one that fits all uses of archives.

The podcasts then began discussing how archives are used, and this answer becomes difficult. When an archive was discovered in Guatemala of egregious police abuse cases, archivists and historians were confronted with a sharp reality – what do you do with these records? Residents wanted to take the records to prosecute government officials immediately, which did happen but not immediately. Instead, the trained archivists

take a step back before opening the records and ask about the political and sociological ramifications of the archive itself. These papers, although mundanely created for mostly intelligence-sharing between police officers, now hold the political power to rectify months of gross abuse and actual murders committed by law enforcement.

Another topic that I found interesting was when archivists at the Guatemalan police archive were confronted with locals that had “known” about the corruption of their police but did not have evidence of it. The best way I took this concept was that there are things that are “known” and that some people don’t want to “know” (government censorship) and so handling of these records, their creation, and the distribution thereof is an inherently political process. Even speaking of the archives is political enough because the story is in the eye of the beholder. The United States trained and worked with the Guatemalan police to develop its archive abilities as a tool of domestic suppression of local opposition. We look at the archive “what is known” as a record of abuse, the state looks at it as a weapon. So did the locals who used that weapon against the government. Both the government and the locals had success in this weapon.